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Workforce Engagement Management (WEM) covers the software that schedules, measures, coaches and assists contact-centre staff, and increasingly the AI agents working beside them.

This week's main developments

- Microsoft now offers, in public preview, its contact-centre AI agents and quality scoring on top of other vendors' contact centres, including Five9, Cisco Webex and Avaya. Microsoft says it bills them on usage credits.
- New York City proposed a rule that customer-service bots must offer a one-step route to a human, with a wait estimate. Firms would also report how many issues bots resolve.
- Comcast's finance chief said its service contact rates fell about 20% this year and named Cresta and Sierra as central to its new model. Job cuts are expected, press reports say.
- Zoom says its new layer gives human and AI agents one shared customer memory. It also added AI role-play practice inside its quality product.
- Microsoft's roadmap now lists an "Intraday Agent" that it says adjusts schedules by itself, due in March 2027. As far as we can tell, no shipped tool we track does this when demand shifts.
- Our periodic check of the report's 18 predictions changes no assessment. Twelve remain supported.

Microsoft sells its contact-centre AI on rivals' platforms

- Microsoft launched Contact Center Intelligence in public preview on 21 October. It takes the AI agents and quality scoring from Dynamics 365 Contact Center to other vendors' contact centres.
- Microsoft names Five9, Cisco Webex Contact Center and Avaya. Its customer Siemens Healthineers says it layers the product onto its Genesys and ServiceNow platforms.
- Microsoft says its quality agent will "Evaluate both agentic and human-led interactions" against one standard. It says the agent reviews past bot conversations today, with real-time scoring "coming soon".
- Microsoft says the agents are "usage-based through Copilot Credits". It has published no price list. It says help for human agents and live coaching will be "available soon".
- The preview is open worldwide except Austria. Microsoft gives no reason.
- **Our view:** Microsoft is separating the AI from the contact centre. The host vendor keeps the human seat, while Microsoft bills its AI by use.
- **Watch:** prices at Microsoft's Ignite conference (17 to 20 November), and how the help for human agents will be priced.

New York City proposes a route to a human

- New York City's consumer agency proposed on 20 October that bots disclose they are automated. Without "a single-step transfer mechanism", such as "Press 0", and the estimated wait, a firm would be presumed in breach.
- Firms would keep logs of bot conversations for three years. Each year they would report how many were resolved without a transfer, and how many customers came back within 72 hours.
- Fines would start at $525, Gothamist reports, citing the agency. The rule would apply to any business serving the city. It is a proposal, not yet a rule.
- A public hearing is set for 19 November. The notice gives a 19 November comment deadline; the city's rules website shows 18 December.
- **Our view:** if adopted, the reports would count a contact as resolved only with no transfer and no repeat within 72 hours. Someone would also have to staff the human queue to a stated wait.
- **Watch:** the hearing, and which comment deadline holds.

Comcast's finance chief says it removed more than 30 million service contacts, and names its AI suppliers

- Comcast's finance chief, Jason Armstrong, said on its results call on 22 October that customer-service contact rates fell "roughly 20%" this year, Deadline reports.
- He said Comcast "eliminated more than 30 million service interactions year to date", Deadline reports.
- He called its work with Cresta and Sierra "central to our new operating model", the Philadelphia Inquirer reports.
- Comcast plans job cuts in its broadband and wireless business and expects a charge of more than $1 billion next quarter, the Los Angeles Times reports, citing Bloomberg. No job number was given.
- The Inquirer says executives did not directly address layoffs on the call. Its sources say cuts are expected and some have started.
- **Our view:** a very large buyer now ties lower contact volume to named AI suppliers. Its measure is contacts avoided, not problems solved.

Zoom joins human and AI work in one layer

- At its Zoomtopia event on 20 October, Zoom launched a "Unified Context Layer". Zoom says it "gives human and AI agents a shared memory of the customer".
- Zoom says its quality product can now score whole cases across agents and back-office teams, including work in other vendors' systems, and that this is available now.

- Zoom's new "Quality Management AI Roleplay" lets agents practise calls before taking them, assessed on criteria such as empathy and policy adherence. Zoom says it is available now.
- CX Foundation, a trade site, reports a new Zoom pricing model: one yearly spending pool for agents, seats, apps and AI. Zoom's own releases do not mention it.
- Zoom also bought Onyx, an open-source workplace search company, on 23 October. Zoom did not disclose terms.
- **Our view:** AI role-play practice now comes inside a large suite's quality product. Specialist training vendors lose one more point of difference.

Salesforce lists European prices and new per-user add-ons

- Salesforce's UK and EU contact-centre pages now show local prices: £100 or €125 per user a month, and £200 or €250 for the version with workforce and quality management.
- On 18 October those pages showed no local prices. Australian and Japanese prices are still "Not currently available".
- Salesforce's price page now lists a quality management add-on at $50, £40 or €50 per user a month. Salesforce says it reviews "100% of human and AI agent interactions".
- Its AI price page now lists an "Agentforce Coworker User License", an assistant for staff, at $50 per user a month. Neither add-on was listed on 18 October.
- The customer-facing AI price is unchanged at $2 per conversation.
- Separately, Salesforce agreed on 20 October to buy Braze, a marketing software company, for about $5.66 billion. Braze does not sell contact-centre software.
- **Our view:** Salesforce now charges per user for staff tools and per use for AI that serves customers. It prices scoring of its AI agents per human user.

Personal agents: a second draft, and more contacts

- The Personal Agent Protocol, led by Sierra and Meta, published version 0.2 of its specification on 24 October. A draft 0.3 is in progress, with some changes marked "Breaking".
- It still has no tagged release or reference implementation. Salesforce and Microsoft are still not on its partner list.
- Salesforce wrote on 19 October that personal agents "Will Drive More Contact Center Traffic Than They Offset".
- Decagon said on 20 October that, for some request types, personal agents are "already increasing contact volume and handle time". Decagon promotes its own protocol.
- In a survey Lorikeet commissioned of about 2,000 US adults, "6.3% said an AI had contacted the company itself".

- **Our view:** two vendors now say personal agents add contacts rather than remove them. That is a new input for staffing plans.

Scheduling: a dated plan for software that acts

- Microsoft added an "Intraday Agent" to its public roadmap on 20 October. Microsoft says it "Automates corrective actions such as adjusting schedules, rescheduling breaks, or reallocating service representatives".
- It is listed as in development, with general availability in March 2027. The entry also lists a September public preview; we found no public preview page.
- Microsoft's two intraday features due in October, volume-spike alerts and a performance report, were still "In development" on 25 October.
- Microsoft's documentation says those alerts "don't reroute conversations, change staffing, or modify the published schedule."
- A shipped Microsoft scheduling feature lists its value as "migration readiness from Verint, Genesys, NICE, UKG, and Calabrio".
- Aspect published two anonymous customer cases on 21 October. Aspect says its rule-based automatic updates made 64.2% and 55.7% of their schedule updates.
- Those updates record schedule exceptions. Aspect says analysts still review flagged events and make the final call.
- Lorikeet's comparison page, updated on 23 October, still says its own intraday mode is "next, not live at launch".
- **Our view:** a large vendor has now dated scheduling software that acts by itself. Every shipped tool we track still alerts, suggests or flags when demand shifts.
- **Watch:** whether Microsoft's October features ship by month-end, and an Intraday Agent preview at Ignite.

Quality and coaching

- Verint said on 22 October that an unnamed insurer scores all its customer interactions automatically. Verint says this equals the work of "approximately 155 full-time employees".
- Verint presents the gain as more time for coaching. It does not say whether those analysts were moved, cut or never hired.
- Microsoft now lets supervisors "edit and override" quality scores, including scores written by its AI, with each change recorded.
- Centrical launched a "Workforce Orchestration System" on 19 October. Centrical says a manager states a goal; the system builds coaching, role-play and targets for people and AI agents, and the manager approves it.

- Centrical's only reported result is one unnamed retailer's customer-satisfaction score, up eight points in a month, IT Brief reports.

Workplace AI rules

- **Emotion AI:** in a post dated 20 October, Aspect says the EU AI Act prohibits inferring agents' emotions from their voice or facial expressions. It advises "limiting emotion detection to the customer's side of the call".
- Aspect is the first vendor we have seen advise customers in public to keep emotion detection off agents. It is advice, not a product change.
- We found no contact-centre vendor renaming, limiting or switching off an emotion, sentiment or wellbeing feature. Zoom says its new case scoring analyses sentiment.
- **California:** Davis Wright Tremaine, a law firm, says the emotion-AI ban allows injunctions, punitive damages and legal fees, plus a $500 penalty per violation. The ban starts on 1 January 2027.
- **EU:** we found no enforcement of the workplace emotion-recognition ban. The Commission's AI Act page added notice of a first quality standard for high-risk AI providers on 19 October.
- **UK:** from March 2027, dismissing and rehiring staff to move them onto nights or weekends will be automatically unfair, the government said on 22 October. Changes inside an agreed availability window remain allowed.
- The UK also plans to ban blacklists "drafted using AI" from April 2027. Guaranteed hours and pay for shifts changed at short notice still have no date.
- The UK government has still not responded to its workplace monitoring consultation.
- **Colorado:** the Attorney General published a cost analysis on 21 October, with no cost figures. The hearing opens on 26 October; comments stay open until it ends.
- **Elsewhere:** Connecticut now requires employers to name where electronic monitoring happens (in force since 1 October). Chile's Senate is weighing a ban on offshore call centres; amendments are due on 2 November.
- **Our view:** pressure on emotion features is arriving through vendor advice and buyers' contracts, not enforcement.

Outsourcers and buyers

- Conduent refinanced its $357 million credit lines and added $90 million on 23 October, its filing says. They now run to May 2029, replacing last week's short extension.
- Conduent's chief executive says the deal supports its aim to be an "AI-led" business-process partner. The filing's terms do not mention AI.
- TTEC Digital launched more than 40 prebuilt AI agents for government services on 20 October. TTEC says they "resolve public service requests from start to finish". It named no price or

customer.

- ArvatoConnect, a UK outsourcer, aims for "70% of interactions to be handled by technology and 30% by people", CNBC reports. Its chief executive says human handling times may need to rise.
- Fusion CX listed in India on 22 October. Its shares rose as high as ₹313 against the ₹289 offer price, then closed near ₹290.
- Consumer Cellular, a US mobile carrier, surveyed customers and prospects aged 50 and over, without giving a sample size. Of its customers, 43% said complete resolution matters most, 43% a live person and 4% speed.
- Barclays will cut 5,000 jobs, citing technology investment, Computer Weekly reports. It did not name contact centres.
- In the Federal Reserve's October survey, five of its twelve districts reported some firms using AI to reduce staff through attrition or slower hiring.
- In Costa Rica a stronger currency raised payroll costs, and in Spain Servinform is cutting staff after losing a tender, Outsource Accelerator reports. Neither report cites AI as the cause.
- **Our view:** the clearest AI effect this week is on contact volume at a large buyer. Job losses at outsourcers still have several causes.

Pricing: no move back to seats

- No tracked vendor moved from per-resolution pricing back to per-seat pricing this week.
- Fin, Zendesk, Lorikeet, Genesys, NiCE and Microsoft prices were unchanged. Lorikeet's page now says "Escalations to a person and unresolved tickets are not charged".
- Salesforce's new per-user prices are for staff tools. Its price per customer conversation is unchanged.

Other company developments

- **Sierra:** says a Stripe partnership lets callers pay during a call. Sierra says 71.3% of calls where a patient starts a payment with Cedar's agent end in a successful payment.
- **Decagon:** launched an Experiment Hub on 22 October to show which change moved resolution and satisfaction. There was no news on the reported sale.
- **Gartner:** vendors report its 2026 contact-centre ranking names NiCE, Genesys and Five9 as Leaders, Microsoft as a Visionary and Zoom as a Niche Player.
- **Peopleware:** says its customer ResQ, an outsourcer, schedules more than 900 advisers from client headcount targets, without a demand forecast.
- **TruAgents:** this provider of AI conversations for regulated firms raised a $3.4 million seed round led by ManchesterStory, Dealroom reports.

- **Automation Anywhere:** its purchase of Boost.ai is expected to close in the fourth quarter, VUX reports.
- **Results dates:** NiCE and Five9 have not announced third-quarter results dates. TaskUs, TP, TTEC and IBEX report on 4 or 5 November, according to secondary sources.

Prediction updates

This is our periodic check of the annual report's eighteen predictions. Assessments combine this week's developments with earlier evidence.

Our assessment: no assessment changed since the last check on 3 October. Twelve are supported, one shows early signs, one is mixed, two are weakened, one is unchanged and one is not triggered.

- **Closest to changing:** autonomous intraday scheduling. Microsoft's dated plan argues for an upgrade. It stays weakened because Lorikeet's 9 October promise has not appeared and no shipped tool we track acts by itself when demand shifts.
- **Completion replaces deflection:** New York's proposal would make resolution counts reportable. Comcast, the largest buyer in the news this week, counts contacts avoided.

Shared platforms and pricing

Prediction	Assessment	Key qualification
One shared human/AI engine	Strong support	Microsoft scores human and AI work against one standard; Zoom gives both one shared customer memory.
Repricing and seat displacement	Supported, qualified	Outcome prices sit beside seats; Comcast cuts contacts while some outsourcers add seats.
Disproof test: return to seat pricing	Not triggered	No tracked price page moved back to seats; Salesforce held its $2 per conversation.

Quality and analytics

Prediction	Assessment	Key qualification
AI changes quality teams' work	Strong support	Verint counts about 155 analysts' work automated; it does not say where they went.

Prediction	Assessment	Key qualification
Specialists defend through depth	Mixed	Microsoft sells quality scoring on rivals' platforms; specialists announced no new depth this week.
The independent middle consolidates	Early signs	No quality specialist was bought; recent deals were in neighbouring markets.

Workforce management

Prediction	Assessment	Key qualification
Autonomous intraday scheduling	Weakened	Microsoft plans software that acts in 2027; shipped tools we track still alert, suggest or flag when demand shifts.
Verint/Calabrio product integration	Unchanged	Verint still lists Calabrio as a separate trademark; no combined product.
Planning combines people and AI	Strong support	New York would require a wait estimate for the human queue; vendors expect personal agents to add contacts.

Performance and engagement

Prediction	Assessment	Key qualification
Emotion-AI restrictions constrain use	Supported	Aspect advises customer-side emotion detection only; no vendor has withdrawn a feature.
Coaching competes on outcomes	Supported, qualified	Centrical and Zoom link findings to coaching; results are vendor-reported.
Simulation protects independents	Weakened	Zoom now includes AI role-play in its quality product.

Agent assistance

Prediction	Assessment	Key qualification
Assist coordinates a shared engine	Strong support	Microsoft's assist agent both resolves alone and helps human staff.
Automated summaries drive adoption	Strong support	No new after-call-work figure since mid-September; summaries are treated as standard.
Human assist stays in seat prices	Supported, qualified	Microsoft bills its AI by use beside the host's seats; Zoom reportedly pools seats and AI.

Autonomous customer experience

Prediction	Assessment	Key qualification
Outcome pricing replaces seats	Supported where published	Fin, Lorikeet, Zendesk and Salesforce prices held; Sierra and Decagon publish none.
Who acts determines the charging model	Strong support	Microsoft and Salesforce charge for staff per user and for customer-facing AI by use.
Completion replaces deflection	Supported, qualified	Cedar reports 71.3% of started payments completed; Comcast counts contacts avoided.

- **Disproof-test qualification:** NiCE, Genesys and Five9 never listed per-resolution prices publicly. As worded, only Salesforce among the large vendors can trigger the test.

What to watch

- **26 October:** Colorado's comment deadline and hearing on the automated-decision rules.
- **28 October:** Microsoft's and ServiceNow's quarterly results.
- **31 October:** whether Microsoft's October intraday alerts and report ship.
- **2 November:** amendment deadline for Chile's offshore call-centre bill.
- **4 and 5 November:** TaskUs, TP, TTEC and IBEX results; Parloa's WAVE Summit in New York.
- **16 November:** TTEC's loan margin rises unless amended.
- **17 to 20 November:** Microsoft Ignite, with possible prices for Contact Center Intelligence.
- **19 November:** New York City's hearing on the bot rule.

- **November:** Salesforce's Casey fixes and its Australia and New Zealand launch.
- **1 January 2027:** California's emotion-AI ban and its human-access law take effect; Colorado's rules take effect.
- **March 2027:** Microsoft's Intraday Agent general availability; UK shift-pattern protections.
- **Open:** Decagon's next step; NiCE and Five9 results dates; a tagged Personal Agent Protocol release; Lorikeet's live scheduling mode; a Comcast job figure; Zoom's own page on its spending pool.
- **New companies surfaced, not yet tracked:** ArvatoConnect (outsourcer), TruAgents (AI conversations), Onyx (search, now part of Zoom), ResQ (outsourcer) and Consumer Cellular (buyer).

Sources

Detailed citations

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